Central Europe and forged a Central European alliance – but this time without Austria. It was the intellectuals in these countries who helped to reinstate the concept as they had already attempted to do during the Communist era and here the contribution of Austrians was important, especially through various NGOs.

The political grouping of the Višegrad Four was meant to facilitate the path of these countries towards accession into the EU, though the philosophical underpinning of the idea (the restoration of Central Europe) was met with a very mixed reaction in Western Europe. In some instances, it was interpreted as an unnecessary attempt to change the reality of the East-West division or as a handy excuse to avoid the label 'Eastern' or even as laying claim to a (Western) European legacy that was not to be shared with Eastern Europeans. Apparently, the idea of Central Europe challenged deeply ingrained views of Eastern Europe as a region inherently different and distant from the West, perhaps even as a place that needs to exist in order to justify the existence of 'Western Europe'. (Interestingly, doubts may have been expressed about the existence of a Central European identity but there never seem to be any doubts that an Eastern European identity exists.)

After their accession to the European Union the four countries continued their close collaboration on various EU policies, becoming a force to be reckoned with, above all in Brussels. However, in the 2010s, the group began to raise eyebrows there and in Western capitals with the increasingly socially conservative policies of some of the governments and with what was regarded as the violation of the rule of law principles in Poland and Hungary. This encouraged the now slightly uncomfortable Czech Republic and Slovakia to look for alternatives, for example, the Slavkov/Austerlitz format that connects the two countries with Austria. To the south, Slovenia that – mainly due to internal lack of consent – had failed to join the V4, in 2020 joined the Austrian idea of a C5 group, i.e. the V4 minus Poland plus Austria and Slovenia. But common interests, especially when it comes to EU funds, continue to prevail and the V4 still get together in Brussels whenever needed. Should the EU decide in the future to broaden the scope of the so-called Quality Majority Voting, the V4 and other groupings of Central European (and other) countries will only gain in importance.

For Slovenia, despite its close historical links to Austria, laying claim to